had spent 36 of the 40 years of his rule as a ring-fenced, downsized Maharaja far removed from the glory of his grandfather, Maharaja Gulab Singh.

The wheel had turned a full circle; the Government of India was not confident enough about the loyalty of Pratap Singh and considered him a weak link in the overall strategic challenge that the state of Jammu and Kashmir faced.[22] The government further had no choice but to intervene in the state's functioning; the ruler's autonomy, or even that of an at arm's length relative, could not be an option. This policy towards the state's government continues to be followed today in 21st-century India. Rulers, politicians and civil servants have come and gone, but the Government of India is still the overarching central authority that firmly continues to exercise its control over Jammu and Kashmir. The challenges that the state faces have remained the same and the options that it has to deal with them, have also remained pretty much the same as they were in the 19th century. The succeeding chapters will dwell on the conformity of the arc of history.